

THE STRATUM METHOD

Lesson 5 · Strata 05 · Resource 1 of 3

THE WANT *and* THE NEED

*The want is what your reader follows.
The need is what they feel.*



The Want and the Need

Four lessons ago you found a behavior your character can't help but repeat. Then the belief underneath it. Then the wound that taught them the belief. Then the lie the wound left behind — the sentence your character carries as fact, not opinion.

Everything up to now has pointed inward. This resource turns the excavation back toward the page. The lie your character believes doesn't stay buried — it goes to work. It organizes what your character chases, what they avoid, and what they can't let themselves reach for. That output has two names: the want, and the need. Learning to tell them apart — and to see why they pull in opposite directions — is what makes a completed psychological profile into a working story engine.

Two Vocabularies, Doing Two Different Jobs

Fiction craft has a name for this distinction, and clinical psychology has a separate name for the mechanism underneath it. Both are useful, and neither is optional. The craft vocabulary tells you what to look for on the page. The psychological vocabulary tells you why it works on a reader at all.

THE CRAFT FRAMEWORK

McKee and Truby — Want vs. Need

Robert McKee's *Story* (1997) established the now-standard distinction between a character's conscious, statable object of desire and an unconscious need the character isn't aware they're missing. John Truby's *The Anatomy of Story* (2007) sharpened the second half into what he calls the "moral need": not simply an emotional gap, but a specific, nameable flaw in how the character treats other people, one the plot is structurally built to expose and correct. Both agree on the load-bearing point: a story runs on two tracks, and they are not the same track.

THE PSYCHOLOGICAL MECHANISM

Higgins — Self-Discrepancy Theory

E. Tory Higgins's self-discrepancy theory (1987) gives the craft distinction its clinical footing. Higgins proposed that people hold multiple self-guides — the actual self (who you believe you are), the ideal self (who you aspire to be), and the ought self (who you believe you're obligated to be) — and that the gap between them produces predictable emotional consequences: dejection when the actual self falls short of the ideal, agitation when it falls short of the ought. The want, in Stratum terms, is the strategy your character has built to close that gap. The need is what actually closes it. Those are rarely the same maneuver — which is precisely why the gap persists.

Put the two frameworks together and the picture sharpens: the lie you found in Lesson 4 is your character's ought self talking. It states, as fact, what your character believes they must be or must do to be acceptable, safe, or worthy. The want is the behavioral strategy the lie recruits to close that discrepancy. The need is what would have to happen — in the actual self, in reality — for the discrepancy to resolve honestly instead of being managed.

The Want — The Lie in Action

The want is not your character's plot goal. A goal is external: win the case, get back home, save the company. Goals live in the world and can be finished — achieved through skill, effort, and circumstance, then closed.

The want lives underneath the goal. It is the psychological strategy the lie directs your character toward — what they are really pursuing, beneath whatever they say they're pursuing, in order to feel safe, validated, or whole. Where the goal can be finished, the want cannot: because it is aimed at closing a self-discrepancy the lie itself keeps reopening. Achieve what the want is pointing toward, and the relief lasts exactly until the lie requires proof again.

“A goal can be achieved. A want built on a lie can never be satisfied — it can only be repeated.”

THE GOAL

External. What the character is trying to accomplish in the world.

Achievable through skill, effort, and circumstance. Can be won or lost. When it's finished, it's finished.

Katniss: survive the Games. Protect Prim. Bring down the Capitol.

THE WANT

Psychological. What the ought-self lie is really pursuing beneath the goal.

Cannot be permanently closed — pursuing it confirms the very discrepancy the lie requires.

Katniss: to guarantee, through constant vigilance, that no one she loves is ever helpless because she failed them.

Why the Want Can't Finish the Job

This is the detail most drafts get wrong: writers hand a character a want, the character gets it, and the story treats that as resolution. But a want built on a lie was never a solvable problem in the first place — it's a coping strategy pointed at an ought-self demand that has no actual ceiling. Every fresh proof of indispensability, every act of vigilance, buys relief that expires the moment circumstances ask for proof again. The want is a treadmill, not a road. That is not a flaw in your character's design. It is the mechanism that keeps them moving for three hundred pages.

The Need — What the Story Must Provide

The need is not what your character wants to need. It's rarely something they're consciously pursuing at all. In Higgins's terms, it is what would have to change in the actual self — not the story your character tells about themselves, but the truth of their situation — for the ought-self discrepancy to resolve honestly. In Truby's terms, it's the correction the plot exists to force.

Three properties separate a genuine need from a wish:

First, it addresses the lie directly. If the lie says worth is conditional on being indispensable, the need is an experience that demonstrates worth independent of usefulness — not a workaround, a direct contradiction.

Second, it cannot be reached through the want's own strategy. This is the structural test. If your character could get the need by doing more of what the want already requires — more vigilance, more performance, more control — you haven't found the real need yet. The real one requires an approach your character has been actively avoiding.

Third, it is usually what the wound took away. The lie formed to protect against what the wound threatened; the need is, at bottom, the thing the wound convinced your character was no longer available to them. The story's job is to test whether that conclusion still holds.

WORKED EXAMPLE — KATNISS

The Want-Need Opposition in Full

Want: to guarantee outcomes — to ensure, through constant vigilance and self-sacrifice, that no one she loves is ever helpless because she failed to protect them. Need: to trust that others can care for themselves and for her; to allow herself to be protected; to discover her value to the people she loves isn't conditional on functioning as their last line of defense. The opposition: every time she positions herself as sole protector, she re-confirms the lie that she is the only protection available — proving to herself, again, that the need is inaccessible. That cycle isn't a flaw in the story. It is the story.

The Structural Opposition

This is the load-bearing requirement, and it's where most first attempts fall short: the want and the need must actively block each other. It is not enough for them to be merely different. Pursuing the want has to make the need harder to reach — ideally impossible to reach by the want's own method. If a character could, in principle, chase the want and receive the need at the same time, you don't yet have a structural conflict. You have two unrelated facts about a character. The gap between want and need is your story's engine only when closing one requires abandoning the other.

NEXT — RESOURCE 2

Resource 2 gives you the technique for finding both — a four-stage method for locating the want, uncovering the need, and verifying the opposition holds against your character's own anchor behavior.